Afghanistan. Most of all, the interplay between these two advocacies strengthens India's capacity to practice restraint at certain times, and be proactive at other opportune moments, and therefore, hones a strategic balance in its policy conduct, a quality that has rescued India from taking rash and immature decisions in Afghanistan.

The argument

Three core intertwined factors drive India's Afghanistan policy debates between the partisans and the conciliators. Conditioned by India's changing economic capacities and geographical disconnect with Afghanistan that gets exaggerated by Pakistan's unfriendly and sometimes hostile presence, these three drivers are:

(1) Striking a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan. The first, and most important, factor shaping India's approach towards Afghanistan is New Delhi's desire to strike a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan. An Afghanistan that is highly dependent on Pakistan, such as during the late-1990s Taliban regime, is not in India's strategic interest. This is because strong Pakistani presence in Afghanistan may hinder India's connectivity to the gas rich Central Asian Republics on one hand, but also allow Pakistani security agencies to use Afghan soil to undermine India's domestic security, especially in Kashmir. In this context, Afghanistan is both a curse and blessing for India and Pakistan. It is as much a theatre of conflict between these South Asian rivals as much it is an arena for cooperation. Whether India competes or cooperates with Pakistan in Afghanistan depends on the following two factors.

(2) International political environment. The second source of India's Afghanistan policy is the constantly evolving international political postures towards Afghanistan. Keen on being viewed as a positive and constructive team player, India's approach towards Kabul is often determined by external pressures and can be reactive in nature. This aspect is critical in the light of New Delhi's desire of having multi-stakeholder presence in Afghanistan lest Kabul becomes dependent on Pakistan's support. But then (given India does not have the capacities to support the Afghan state all by itself), whichever international actor plays the biggest role in that sphere will have the greatest leverage on domestic Afghan politics. If the Taliban regime was structurally dependent on Pakistan, the post-9/11 Afghan state is dependent on US support. This fact has profoundly shaped India's approach towards Kabul. For instance, Hamid Karzai, who rose to power with US support at the 2001 Bonn Conference, was a fait accompli for India (and also other countries) that was wary of Karzai's links with Pakistan. Indian officials wanted a candidate from the anti-Taliban United Front to gain power, but relented to American desires, embracing Karzai eventually.

(3) Domestic politics of Afghanistan. The third source that drives India's Afghanistan policy is the fluctuating degrees to which various political factions in Afghanistan want to engage with India. Despite the tremendous goodwill that India enjoys among Afghans, different political factions prioritise India differently. If New Delhi enjoyed Karzai's hospitality, it (briefly) felt